THE KEEFE TEAM · JLA REALTY · ALEDO, TEXAS

Before You Buy Your Child's First Horse

If your child has started asking for a horse, you may be wondering whether this is a passing interest or the beginning of something wonderful. Either way, buying a horse is a big commitment, and the horse is only one part of the decision. We love seeing families get involved with horses, and we know how much easier it goes when parents have realistic expectations before bringing one home. This guide is a starting point, not a substitute for a qualified instructor, veterinarian and experienced horse professional.



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1. Start with lessons, not a purchase

Before shopping for a horse, give your child regular time around horses with a reputable instructor. Riding is only part of it. Your child should also learn how to catch, lead, groom, tack up and safely handle a horse on the ground.

Ask the instructor whether your child is ready for the responsibility of ownership. Consider leasing or part-leasing a suitable lesson horse before buying. And make sure at least one adult is prepared to take responsibility for care, costs and decisions.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **A year of lessons tells you more than any sale ad will.**

2. The right first horse is not always the prettiest one

For a beginner, temperament, training, soundness and suitability matter more than color, pedigree or potential. An older, experienced horse with a steady disposition may be a much better match than a young horse that needs training. The general rule: the younger or more inexperienced the rider, the older and more experienced the horse should be.

Have your child's instructor help evaluate candidates and observe the horse being handled and ridden. See the horse in its normal environment, and ask about its history, habits, medical needs and workload. Arrange an independent pre-purchase veterinary exam; it helps assess risk, though it can't guarantee future soundness. Avoid buying a horse sight unseen or relying only on videos or a seller's description.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Young rider, old horse. Every experienced horse person will tell you the same thing.**

3. Know what horse ownership really costs

The purchase price may be the least expensive part of owning a horse over time. Make a monthly budget and leave room for emergencies. Costs vary widely by location, horse, facility and level of care, but plan for: board or property upkeep; hay, feed, supplements and bedding; routine veterinary care, vaccinations, dental care, parasite management and farrier visits; lessons, training, tack, helmets, grooming supplies and equipment replacement; trailer transport, insurance if appropriate, and an emergency veterinary fund.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Parent check: could you keep paying for and caring for the horse if your child lost interest, got injured or left for college?**

4. Boarding or keeping a horse at home?

Boarding at a reputable barn gives a first-time family access to instructors, experienced help and facilities. Ask exactly what's included in the board fee, who handles emergencies and whether there is reliable supervision.

Keeping a horse at home offers convenience, but it also means daily feeding and checks, facility maintenance, manure management, emergency planning and arranging backup care when you travel. Horses are social animals, so companionship and turnout should be part of the plan.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Many families board for the first year and bring the horse home once they know what they're doing.**

5. If you need horse property, check the practical details

This is where we can help with the real estate side. A property can have plenty of acreage and still be a poor fit for horses. Before making an offer, here's what we'd check: whether deed restrictions, HOA rules, local ordinances and land-use requirements allow your intended horse use; usable land, safe fencing, reliable water, drainage, shelter and a workable feeding and turnout setup; access for a truck and horse trailer, deliveries, veterinarians and emergency vehicles; space for hay and equipment, manure handling and any riding area you hope to have; and the cost to add or repair facilities, and whether proposed improvements are permitted.

There is no universal "right number of acres" for a horse. The answer depends on local rules, soil and pasture conditions, management and the number of horses. Confirm the specifics before buying.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Our full horse-property guide covers each of these in detail.**

6. Safety is everyone's responsibility

Horses are large animals with quick reactions. Even a quiet, experienced horse can spook. A properly fitted, certified equestrian helmet, appropriate boots, supervision and consistent handling rules are essential.

Teach children to approach, lead, tie, groom and move around horses safely with qualified supervision. Have an emergency contact plan and know who can transport the horse if needed. Keep a veterinarian's number handy and learn to recognize changes in appetite, movement and behavior. Do not leave a child solely responsible for managing a horse or making medical decisions.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Helmet on, every ride, no exceptions. Start the habit before the first horse.**

7. Get involved before you buy

One of the best ways to learn is to spend time with other horse families. Lessons, volunteering, clinics and youth programs help your child discover which activities they enjoy and what owning a horse actually involves.

We help lead the Parker County 4-H Novice Horse Project. If your family is interested, ask us about the current program schedule, participation requirements and how to get connected. Please confirm enrollment and horse-access requirements with the local 4-H program; they can change.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **4-H is the best-kept secret in horse country. Ask us how to get started.**

Questions to answer as a family

Is our child taking lessons consistently and enjoying horse care as well as riding? Who will feed, check and care for the horse every day, including holidays and vacations? What is our realistic monthly budget and emergency reserve? Who is our trusted instructor or horse professional? Will we board, lease first or keep a horse at home? If buying land, have we verified restrictions, facilities and improvement costs?

Our advice

Take your time. Find a good instructor, spend time at the barn and ask plenty of questions. A well-matched horse and a realistic plan will do far more for your child than rushing into a purchase.

If you're thinking about your child's first horse, or wondering whether your current property will work, we're happy to visit with you. We can help you think through the property side and connect you with the right questions to ask about getting started.

Questions we hear most

How old should my child be before getting a horse?

There's no magic age. Readiness shows up as consistent lessons, interest in the chores and not just the riding, and an adult willing to own the responsibility. Many families lease first.

How many acres do we need?

It depends on local rules, pasture quality, management and how many horses. Some properties keep horses well on a couple of acres with good management; others struggle on ten. We'll help you evaluate a specific property.

Can we keep a horse in a neighborhood like Aledo or Willow Park?

Sometimes, on the right lot, but deed restrictions, HOA rules and city ordinances decide it. We check this before you fall in love with a place.

What's the Parker County 4-H Horse Project?

A youth program where kids learn horsemanship, showing and care with volunteer leaders (that's us). It's one of the best ways to find out if your family is ready for a horse. Ask us how to join.

Thinking about a first horse, or whether your place will work for one? Let's talk.

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